



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Mater Dei Apostolate

School Website: <https://materdeiapostolate.org/>

January 7, 2026

Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

Overall Classification: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL**Executive Summary**

Mater Dei Apostolate (Cloquet, MN, 55720) presents a clearly Catholic, mission-driven program that reaffirms classical education with a Catholic orientation. The school emphasizes formation of character through a Catholic intellectual tradition, daily liturgical life (Mass, Adoration, pilgrimages), and a commitment to making high-quality education affordable and accessible. The public materials show strong Religious and Metaphysical Foundations and a purposeful emphasis on formation over mere information, and they signal a genuine partnership with families (parents as primary educators). However, while the program proclaims classical aims (e.g., a classical curriculum and partnership with Kolbe Academy for the core curriculum), explicit references to core classical pedagogy elements such as explicit Great Books, the Seven Liberal Arts (Trivium/Quadrivium), or visible Socratic/Scholastic methods in the public materials are less pronounced than in established classical schools. Taken together, the school demonstrates substantial classical alignment, but certain hallmark pedagogical and curricular specifics are not as explicitly documented in the public materials as in the classical rubric's strongest demonstrations.

Overall classification by category:

- Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL
- Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL
- Element 3: Curriculum — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 5: Faculty — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Aggregate classification: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

What would move the needle: Concrete articulations of Great Books and explicit Trivium/Quadrivium exposure, explicit description of Socratic/Scholastic pedagogy in high school, and a more explicit “living curriculum” portrait of the faculty would move Mater Dei toward a fuller CLASSICAL classification.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL**Evidence**

- The school describes itself as a Catholic lay apostolate and emphasizes authentic Catholic formation (turn0file0; turn0file2). It positions itself as a Catholic hybrid high school in Minnesota, with a mission centered on Catholic formation.
- Public materials emphasize daily Mass, Adoration, Confession, spiritual retreats and pilgrimages as part of student life (turn0file6; turn0file18).
- A history statement explicitly grounds education in “the truth, beauty and goodness” of the Catholic faith (turn0file9).
- The program is framed within the Catholic intellectual tradition and a pedagogy aligned to a Catholic formation, including the note that instructors teach in a Catholic, formation-focused context (turn0file6).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present (examples from the public materials aligned with the Six Essentials lexicon): truth, goodness, beauty; liturgy; Mass; Adoration; sacred tradition; theology; Catholic; liturgical life; sacred worship. The explicit phrase grounding faith in truth, beauty, and goodness appears (turn0file9). The site also emphasizes liturgical practices (Mass, Adoration) and Catholic identity (turn0file6; turn0file0; turn0file2).
- Negative keywords: None evident in the public materials (no explicit secular relativism, secular humanism, or values-neutral language found in the accessible content).

Why this rating

- The materials show a robust religious/metaphysical orientation: a Catholic identity, liturgical life, and a clear claim that truth, goodness, and beauty guide the formation of students. The presence of Mass/Adoration and a stated Catholic intellectual tradition underpin a CLASSICAL alignment in this category.

Citations: Catholic identity and mission lines (turn0file0; turn0file2); daily Mass/Adoration/Pilgrimages (turn0file6); formation emphasis and Catholic tradition (turn0file6); “truth, beauty and goodness” grounding (turn0file9); Mass daily (turn0file18).

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The mission emphasizes formation and formation-oriented aims, focusing on education and formation of high school students in a Catholic context (turn0file0; turn0file2).
- The history/mission materials articulate a vision of forming wisdom and virtue within a Catholic framework, rather than simply preparing students for jobs (turn0file9).
- The program describes itself as providing higher-education prep rooted in the Catholic intellectual tradition and emphasizes accessibility and authenticity (turn0file0; turn0file2; turn0file6).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: formation; virtue; wisdom; human flourishing (explicit phrase in the Six Elements doc but reflected via formation/wisdom/virtue in the school materials); liberal education/paideia (implied by “classical curriculum rooted in Catholic tradition”); contemplation and restfulness (explicit reference to scholé concepts appears only in the general classical lexicon, but the school’s emphasis on formation and Catholic tradition aligns with this spirit).
- Negative keywords: none explicitly present in the school materials (no explicit emphasis on workforce readiness or job-training as a primary goal).

Why this rating

- The public materials position education as formation of the whole person (formation and virtue) rather than mere information or job preparation. The explicit religious framing reinforces the classical aim of forming human excellence in wisdom and virtue. While the catechized goals are clear, there is less explicit, text-level articulation of “pursuit of true, good, beautiful” in a universal sense beyond the Catholic context; however, the core aim aligns strongly with classical formation.

Citations: Formation/high-level aims (turn0file0; turn0file2); “formation... wisdom and virtue” wording (turn0file9); Catholic intellectual tradition for curriculum (turn0file6).

Element 3: Curriculum — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence

- Mater Dei states that core courses utilize the classical high school curriculum of Kolbe Academy, indicating a classical orientation in coursework (turn0file6).
- A Full Curriculum is referenced (Curriculum PDF) on the site, suggesting structured classical coursework (turn0file3; turn0file14).

- The program is described as rooted in the Catholic intellectual tradition (turn0file6).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: classic/classical/curricular alignment; Kolbe Academy as the core provider; Full Curriculum (PDF) in the public materials; “classical curriculum” language appears in the public content (turn0file6).
- Negative keywords present (diminishing classical cues): Explicit references to Seven Liberal Arts (Trivium/Quadrivium), Great Books, or “Great Conversation” are not clearly present in the public text. The site does not consistently enumerate the Seven Liberal Arts or Great Books in the accessible public content (though the Kolbe link implies a classical tradition; Great Books/Great Conversation language is not explicit in the accessible excerpts provided here).

Why this rating

- The school demonstrates a clear classical orientation by adopting a classical curriculum through Kolbe Academy and sharing a formal curriculum document. However, the public content does not consistently articulate all elements of the six-element checklist for Curriculum (e.g., explicit Great Books/-Great Conversation, Trivium/Quadrivium, or explicit historical/humanities integration beyond the Kolbe framework). This partial yet substantial alignment justifies a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating.

Citations: Classical curriculum and Kolbe Academy reference (turn0file6); Full Curriculum PDF mention (turn0file3; turn0file14); Catholic intellectual tradition grounding (turn0file6).

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence

- Public materials emphasize a classical curriculum delivery but do not explicitly enumerate core pedagogical approaches such as Socratic seminars, recitation, or memory work in the high school setting (no explicit function of Socratic pedagogy appears in the accessible excerpts).
- The site foregrounds formation, Catholic life, and experiential elements (Mass, Adoration, pilgrimages, service) that align with contemplative and humane pedagogy, but the explicit classroom methods like narrations, memory work, or memory-based drills are not clearly described in the accessible materials (aside from general formation and religious elements).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: contemplation/scholé (referenced conceptually in the classical lexicon; not explicitly in school text but implied by the formation-focused, contemplative Catholic education), virtue formation (apparent in mission and history lines), and a “living curriculum” vibe via formation advisors and teacher-student relationships (turn0file18).
- Negative keywords present: explicit statements about specific classical pedagogy (Socratic seminars, memory work, recitation, chanting) are not evident in the public materials. Without explicit articulation of these methods, the category cannot be fully CLASSICAL.

Why this rating

- The program signals classical aims through curriculum and formation but does not clearly articulate the range of classical pedagogical methods described in the Six Elements (e.g., Socratic dialogue, chanting, narration, memory work). The absence of explicit pedagogy statements in the public content leads to a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL designation for Pedagogy.

Citations: Instructors and pedagogy articulation (turn0file6); daily Mass and formation emphasis (turn0file18); absence of explicit Socratic/Scholé pedagogy in exposed content.

Element 5: Faculty — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence



- The public materials indicate that “qualified Mater Dei instructors teach each course,” confirming a standard of qualified teaching staff (turn0file6).
- The site mentions “Formation Advisors” and a structured teacher-student support system (turn0file18).
- The materials do not contain explicit statements about a “living curriculum,” a portrait of a teacher, or a specific faculty profile in the lexicon, though “Instructors” and “Formation Advisors” imply a careful and relational faculty structure.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: teacher as mentor/guide concepts (formation advisors; qualified instructors; Catholic formation). The phrase “the living curriculum” appears in the Six Elements lexicon but is not clearly used in Mater Dei’s public text; however, the presence of formation advisors and qualified instructors is consistent with a quality faculty image.
- Negative keywords present: Absence of explicit “portrait of a teacher,” “faculty as living curriculum,” or “collegial culture” language in the public content. No explicit statements about collaborative faculty culture beyond standard instructor roles.

Why this rating

- The school demonstrates credible faculty capacity via equipped instructors and formation advisors, but it does not publicly articulate the full “living curriculum” portrait or a formal faculty culture as a central feature. This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating for Faculty.

Citations: Instructors and formation advisors (turn0file6; turn0file18).

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The public content signals a strong partnership with families and an emphasis on parental roles in education (parents as primary educators is explicitly stated in the curriculum context) (turn0file6).
- The materials describe affordable, accessible, and authentically Catholic education designed for home-school families, with parents as essential partners to education (turn0file0; turn0file2).
- The history materials underscore parents’ rights and duties to seek Catholic education for their children (turn0file9).
- The site’s structure (Governing Board, Instructors, Location, FAQs) implies ongoing parental and community involvement in governance and operations (turn0file3).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: partnership with families; parents as primary educators; Catholic family involvement; community and parental formation (turn0file6; turn0file9). The Lexicon’s category highlights “Partnership with Families” and “Formation of Affections,” which align with Mater Dei’s content about parental involvement and family-centered formation though those exact phrases aren’t all quoted verbatim in every public page.
- Negative keywords: None evident in the public texts. There is no explicit shift toward a consumer model or limited parental access; in fact, the content indicates parental involvement and access via governance and formation opportunities.

Why this rating

- The school clearly prioritizes parent partnership and family involvement and frames parents as primary educators, aligning with CLASSICAL expectations for Parents & Community.

Citations: Parents as primary educators (turn0file6); mission to homeschool families and Catholic family formation (turn0file0; turn0file2); parental rights language (turn0file9).

What Would Move the Needle

- Element 3 (Curriculum): Add explicit public documentation of Great Books selection and the Great Conversation, and explicitly spell out the Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric; arithmetic, geometry, music, astronomy) in site language, along with any classical languages (Latin/Greek). This would strengthen the explicit curricular mapping to classical standards.
- Element 4 (Pedagogy): Publicly articulate explicit classical pedagogical methods (Socratic seminars or Paideia-style seminars, narration, memorization, chanting, and Scholé days). Demonstrating these methods in the public materials would move Pedagogy to CLASSICAL.
- Element 5 (Faculty): Include a visible “Living Curriculum” portrait of the faculty, a clear faculty profile, and describe a collegial faculty culture and ongoing faculty formation in classical pedagogy. This would strengthen the Faculty category to CLASSICAL.
- Element 2 (School Purpose and Goal): While the formation emphasis is strong, articulating a more explicit articulation of the telos (truth, goodness, beauty) in a broad, non-denominational sense could strengthen the universal classical case while preserving Catholic identity.
- Element 6 (Parents & Community): Maintain and expand public-facing opportunities for parent formation (book studies, classical education seminars) and explicit invitation for parents to visits, further solidifying the parental partnership as a consistent hallmark of classical practice.

ABSTRACT

Mater Dei Apostolate (Cloquet, MN, 55720) presents a robust Catholic, formation-focused program with a strong public articulation of religious identity, liturgical life, and a classical curricular orientation via Kolbe Academy. The school’s materials clearly reflect Religious and Metaphysical Foundations and School Purpose/Goal, with explicit references to daily Mass, Adoration, pilgrimages, and a Catholic intellectual tradition anchoring the curriculum. The Curriculum is clearly classical in orientation through the Kolbe Academy link and Full Curriculum references; however, explicit mentions of Great Books, the Seven Liberal Arts, and detailed pedagogical methods (e.g., Socratic seminar, narrations, memory work) are less visible in the public materials, yielding a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating for Curriculum and Pedagogy. Faculty is evidenced through instructor quality and formation-advisor structures, but lacks a fully explicit portrayal of a “living curriculum” faculty ethos in public content, again yielding SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL. Parents & Community are highly engaged, with explicit parent-as-educator framing and openness to parental involvement, firmly CLASSICAL.

Overall, Mater Dei Apostolate (Cloquet, MN, 55720) aligns with classical education in many respects, especially in its religious foundations, formation goals, and family partnership. The aggregate rating is SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL, with concrete steps available to move toward full CLASSICAL alignment (explicit Great Books/Trivium/Quadrivium articulation, explicit pedagogical methods, a more formalized living-curriculum faculty portrayal, and expanded parent education offerings).

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

By reading or using this document, you acknowledge and accept the limitations described above.